

it doesn't hurt to have a little idea about video editing before you start using any editing tool, but thanks to Microsoft's help ([F1]), even absolute beginners will feel right at home in a few hours flat.

All your options are clearly visible, such as importing video, adding transitions, effects and various others. Just import a video file, split it at the points you want to edit out, double-click on segments to select them, press [Delete] to delete them—it's all classic Microsoft-style ease of use.

In the preview pane, which is basically Windows Media Player, you can preview any effects that you have thought about applying, and safely change your mind without having to stop and start from scratch. If you do mess up, just use the good old [Ctrl] + [Z] command to step back in time and get yourself out of trouble.

The drawback is that large files can take a long time to import, especially if all your videos are over the 100 MB mark. Still, if you plan on just doing very basic editing, such as adding a title and credits, and splicing together some clips, it will be a lot cheaper and easier to just use WMM instead of buying professional software. You could always take a walk, make some coffee or do something healthy and fun while you wait for those large videos to be imported into Windows Movie Maker!

Overall, this software is a must-try for beginners, as many people realise that they really don't want any more functionality and features than what WMM has to offer. Plus, did we mention it's free?

4.1.2 VirtualDub www.virtualdub.org

If you want a little more power in your hands, you have to try VirtualDub. It's very light when it comes to system resources, and opens large files quite fast for editing. It has a slightly unusual interface—if you're used to Windows Movie Maker, that is—and sports the standard two-display look of most video editors.